Are You a Good Witch or . . .

with poems by Anna Sandy-Elrod, Marisca Pichette, Evan J. Peterson, and Amanda Gorman

When I am Dorothy Gale by Anna Sandy-Elrod

The curtain comes crashing down
and there I am, ruby-footed and murderous,
doing it all for the bloated shadow
of a little man. How foolish I have been
again and again, poppy-cocked
and clumsy, letting the boom of a voice, the cast
of a giant, tease me into storming
the castle to take what I never lacked. What is
more incarnadine: the glitter of these
shoes or the myth of blood now on my hands.
I look at the man and he looks back,
the fury of being caught pinking his cheeks.
I am not the heroine, and I know that
too late. He has no power to give me, after all,
the fading of his theatrics, and if he did,
I understand he'd keep it. We all fell for green,

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called it real. There's no place like money.
There's no seduction like a beast of sewn-up skins,
a cotton ball on fire, a thrown voice
that tells us what we want to hear. Which of us
escapes? He told the lie; I did the killing.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Anna Sandy-Elrod
On-line Magazine: The Florida Review
https://cah.ucf.edu/floridareview/article/when-i-am-dorothy-gale/
Publisher: University of Central Florida
Date (Month/Year): Unlisted

INTRODUCTION

In 1939 Frank L Baum's book was forever captured on film in The Wizard of Oz. But it was more than the leap from black-and-white to technicolor that fascinated viewers. The question "Are you a good witch or a bad witch?" lives on in the canon of the Ozian world.

And yet the question itself is problematic. It forces a simplistic, binary view of people, ignoring the complexity of intentions and motivations. Even Dorothy struggles to answer. Instead replying "I'm not a witch at all."

In Wicked (the book, the Broadway musical or the recently released movie), the question of good and evil is phrased a bit differently: "Are people born wicked or do they have wickedness thrust upon them?" For often what we perceive as wickedness is often rooted in pain, prejudice and misunderstanding.

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Are You a Good Witch or . . . including the poems When I am Dorothy Gale by Anna Sandy-Elrod, Are You a Good Witch by Marisca Pichette, Because of the Wonderful Things She Does by Evan J. Peterson and Do Us Good by Amanda Gorman

Are You a Good Witch by Marisca Pichette

Are you a good witch
or a bad witch?
    As if there's an answer
    earned, inscribed
    in bubbles
    reflecting an inverse
    crown.

Whip-stitched into the lining
of that question I see good
and bad like rhinestones
dressing up inevitability.

Are you a *(pause)* witch
or a *(pause)* witch?
You are a witch.
    I am a witch.

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You are my witch and I
    am yours.

We wave wands or
broomsticks, conjuring
stars or demons or cramps
waiting for diamonds to stop
houses from falling
on our heads.

No water for us, cup covered
on the bar
    iced coffee only,
    to be safe to be dry to be
un-toxicated
un-blamable
inflammable.

Perched on the lip of a bubbling cauldron
I've spent decades learning
how best to melt.

How to slide out of sight
into the creases between the red light
and the green--

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Sopping streets,

salt spraying

witches on car tires

witches on sidewalks

witches in oil puddles

witches staining heels

hems faces cuffs—

following instead of being

followed, trailing in defiance

of being trailed.

Witches melt from clubs to

hearts to doorsteps, spreading dark

spots to remind the world

that magic really does

exist.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Marisca Pichette
On-line Magazine: Strange Horizons, Issue 29
http://strangehorizons.com/poetry/are-you-a-good-witch/
Publisher: Strange Horizons.com
Date (Month/Year): November 29, 2021

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Because of the Wonderful Things She Does by Evan J. Peterson

Oh, Dorothy.

You slap lions &

defeat witches,

you help grown men

become kings,

you help fake

wizards get clean,

you dry their tears

on your gingham

dress—big jobs

for an eight-

year-old. The Scarecrow

learned

to strategize,

& the Tin Man always

loved, grieved

over crushing a bug.

& the Lion

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ever had courage,
lacked only confidence

till Oz, the Great
And Terrible Fraud,
slipped him

a syrupy placebo.
But you, Dorothy?

You never
truly had the power
to take yourself

home. Sure, the shoes—
those silver, tap-dancing

teleporters,
but they're not *yours*.
Home was always

beyond you, as you
took care of marvelous men.

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Men who don't
eat nor sleep but weep
into your skirts—

ain't that just like a man?
(ain't you too young to know?)

And of course
there's your curious habit
of killing people

by accident. What Oz
himself couldn't do,

nor the Good
Witch of the North.
Pig-tailed assassin,

you freed slaves,
Winkies & Munchkins,

a sort of reverse
John Wilkes Booth.
You kill with scrub water,

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you kill with your house.

You kill

like a girl.

& that humbug, that huckster,

that flimflamming

grifter, that shuffler,

that hustler, that swindler

duped you. Oz,

that papier mache

puppet head,

pressed you to kill.

Here's rope, so hang:

no hot air

balloon ride on your

bucket list.

Just cute shoes

to walk you back

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to bleak, flat

Kansas: happy

dust-bowl,

Dorothy, you Not-Queen

of Oz.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Evan J. Peterson
On-line Transcript:
https://thebushwickbookclubseattle.com/wizard-of-oz-inspired-poetry-from-evan-j-peterson-because-of-the-wonderful-things-she-does/
Publisher: The Bushwick Book Club Seattle
Date (Month/Year): Performed at the 42nd annual Northwest Folklife Festival. May 2013

Do Us Good by Amanda Gorman

Are we

born wicked or

do we have wickedness thrust upon us?

Are we born bad, or brave?

There is a world we miss when we misbehave,

But we miss just as much when we misconstrue.

When we distrust what is different and detest what is

new.

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History is written by the victors,

and villains are embittered by the forcible and the few.

But through how we live, our children learn:

What we earn when we're earnest

and what we forge when we forgive.

Only with a decency do we discover:

People are not born evil,

we are born equal;

Green,

not with envy, but what we envision in each other:

A sentimental mankind finding ourselves even in the dark.

There is a goodness that knows in our hearts,

No one is wicked at birth.

We are born to light the wick of the earth.

We are all that girl:

When something changes within us,

something changes in this vast world.

We will never be the same;

This feeling, fervid as a flame has a name:

Unadulterated loving;

Rushing,

Flooding.

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Together we will stare down the emerald tower;

We will not cower.

We will not let our power take over us.

But let ourselves take back our power.

We won't just say we're sorry now.

Rejoicify that we're glad and grateful just to be seen and not listened to.

We'll dream, soar into the blue, rise up to a new reality,

Because defending the good is how we defy gravity.

So if you dare to find us, look to our West-turned eyes!

Everyone won't do good deeds.

But all deserve the chance to try;

To be understood as we should.

And if this they would mourn as wicked.

Then let this wicked do us

good.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Amanda Gorman
On-line Transcript:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=BPOVo3_pyos
(Transcript available)
Publisher: YouTube.com
Date (Month/Year): November 26, 2024

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